

The return of LAN Tournaments in India - What's going to be different this time?

With an increase in the popularity of eSports, what are the changes we can expect to the returning LAN scene?

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eSports has been around for fairly long time now and throughout the entirety of the growth process, there has been one thing that has remained constant - LAN.

What started off as a fun way for friends to get together and duke it out in the early 2000s, has now seemingly become synonymous with the highest level of competitive play.

The History of LANs in India

While there's no record of when the first ever LAN tournament was played in the country, there has always been a love for gaming cafes. The first one was opened in Bengaluru back in 1996. However, it might not be what you're picturing right now. It did not have RGB lighting, nor did it have state of the art peripherals. In fact, it was a Cafe Coffee Day. This was no regular CCD however, it boasted two full floors with PCs which were ready to be gamed on. It soon became a hotspot for gamers of all ages to play at, which largely helped in fostering an inclusive atmosphere in the gaming scene of the city.

Very soon, India started having its very own eSports tournaments for all the world renowned eSports - From Dota 2 to the ever popular Counter Strike for which the country even managed to produce Major worthy teams!

Throughout this entire period, the LAN scene in India continued to grow and very soon, we saw red carpet events such as Dreamhack and ESL make their way into India giving the



ESL along with Dreamhack made eSports bigger in India

people more of what they wanted. These events were very well received by the Indian public and encouraged a career in eSports for the youth that wanted to make a name for themselves. Ever since then, a few people banded together to ensure the growth of eSports in India and today we see boutique Tournament Organisers which have set up a large base of operations and are working to get eSports to the level that it can be at. In other words, unlocking the full and true potential of eSports.

The Coming of the PC Era

The country had developed a thriving mobile gaming scene when the Pandemic hit, already seeing multiple LANs being held for the then popular PUBG Mobile.

For the longest time, PUBG Mobile took the main stage and saw tournament after tournament, even developing an insanely active Tier 2 and 3 scene which brought into existence millions of players who wanted to make a name for themselves.

The LANs for the game gave players inspiration to make it big. Seeing their favourite players come together to duke it out face to face in an arena while being watched by millions. One can only

imagine what an ecstatic moment that might be for someone who wished to be at the same level. This exact emotion is what made people show up at the events and make them successful.

However, ever since the pandemic started, such events obviously became a thing of the past as everything shifted on to the online world.

Unfortunately, PUBG Mobile got banned and the booming world of eSports slowly started regressing to the way things were, with a lot more enthusiasts waiting for things to go back to normal this time around.

Of course, the pandemic was in no hurry to leave and so, as time passed, nothing made people as excited as the first few tournaments for the newly introduced tac FPS shooter by League of Legends' developers, Riot Games' Valorant.

Valorant was not only able to capitalise on the millions of people wanting a title to play, but also filled the void that had been left due to the absence of PUBG Mobile in the world of eSports in India.

Valorant introduced people to the wonders of PC gaming and Indian stars who had already made a name for



Valorant came as a lifesaver for Indian eSports